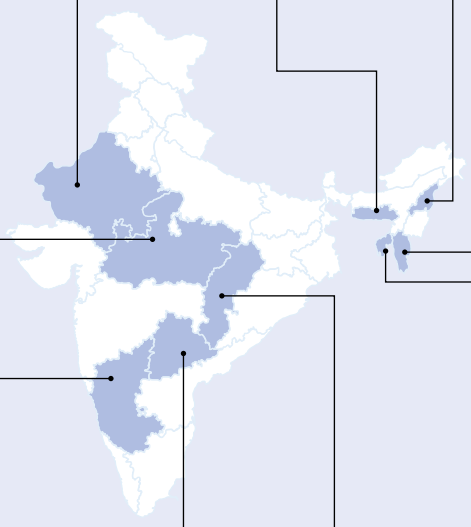
THE NINE TESTS OF 2023

As the yatra concludes, these nine states will be going to the polls this year. The Congress is the incumbent power in two, challenger in three, non-existent in four



RAJASTHAN

With the tussle between Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot and his former deputy Sachin Pilot unresolved and anti-incumbency running high, the party is doing a good job of ruining its chances

200 | 100 | 39%

MADHYA PRADESH

The tussle over the CM's post saw Jyotiraditya Scindia depart to the BJP along with many Congress leaders, toppling the Kamal Nath government. The party hopes for a comeback based on anti-incumbency against the BJP

230 | 117 | 41%

KARNATAKA

Strong organisation and anti-incumbency against ruling BJP work in Congress favour. But the feud between CM aspirants Siddaramaiah and D.K. Shivakumar could be the party's undoing

224 | 80 | 38%

MEGHALAYA

Snatching defeat from the jaws of victory, the Congress could not muster enough support to form the government despite emerging as the single largest party in 2018. All its MLAs have since defected

60 | 21 | 29%

TELANGANA

A rapidly surging BJP threatens to displace Congress as the main Opposition party. The latter is beset by factional wars among the local leaders

119 | 19 | 28%

NAGALAND

The party has a bare presence in the state and nil representation in the assembly. Desperately looking for an ally to contest the 2023 assembly polls, it is unlikely to make any impact

60 | 0 | 2%

MIZORAM

In 2018, the Congress received a body blow when it won just five seats, down from 34 in 2013. There have been no signs of any revival since

40 | 5 | 30%

TRIPURA

Out of power for almost three decades, the Congress is banking this time on the return of veteran Sudip Roy Barman to the party fold and a probable alliance with the CPI(M) and indigenous tribal parties

60 | 0 | 2%

CHHATTISGARH

One Congress-ruled state that has better chances of re-election despite the ongoing feud between Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel and cabinet minister T.S. Singh Deo. BJP organisation remains weak

90 | 68 | 43%

● Total assembly seats ● Seats Congress won in 2018 ● Congress vote share in 2018

THE REBRANDING OF RAHUL GANDHI

The Bharat Jodo Yatra is indeed a big, bold step towards saving the Congress ship from sinking altogether, but it is also seen an attempt to reclaim the leadership of the Gandhi family, particularly of Rahul. Since he formally joined politics in 2004, after contesting and winning family pocket borough Amethi, his political career has been a roller-coaster ride that has seen more troughs than crests. Rahul came into his own in the 2009 general election, when he helped the Congress win 21 of the 80 Lok Sabha seats in UP, something the party had been unable to do in two decades. With the Congress notching up an overall tally of 206 seats, it enabled the UPA to retain power at the Centre. But Rahul's ambivalence in joining the Manmohan Singh cabinet during the second UPA government saw him and the party pay a heavy price in the 2014 general election. It was at this point that the perception of Rahul as a dilettante dynast, who had risen to power more by the virtue of his inheritance than any real achievement, gained ground, and the BJP started taunting him as '*pappu*' (naïve), '*shehzada*' (prince) and Rahul Baba.

Rahul's fortunes seemed to rise again in 2018 when, as